

THE QURAN DECIPHERMENT PROJECT



The Man at the Center

A Portrait of Muhammad as Refracted Through the Qur'an



A research deliverable of the
Quran Decipherment Project

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The Man at the Center of All of It

A long essay, drawing on a hundred-plus findings of the Qur'ān Decipherment Project, on the figure the book keeps refusing to describe.

There is a historical person the argument of this essay will keep circling back to. He is the paradox at the centre of a text he did not claim to author. Before we look at any of the evidence — before any verse counts, any rings, any statistical tails — we ought to look at him, as he stood in the world.

His name was Muḥammad ibn ʿAbd Allāh ibn ʿAbd al-Muṭṭalib ibn Hāshim. He was born in Mecca in the late sixth century, probably around 570 CE, into the clan of Banū Hāshim of the tribe of Quraysh. His father died before he was born; his mother died when he was six. He was raised first by his paternal grandfather and then, after the grandfather's death, by his paternal uncle Abū Ṭālib. There is not a single item in this biography that any pre-modern reader would have chosen to ennoble a founder: orphan, fatherless, without a living mother, dependent first on an old man and then on an uncle whose resources were modest. He was a shepherd as a boy and a caravan merchant as a young man. He did not attend the schools of the ḥanīfs, the Jewish scholars of Yathrib, the Syriac monks of Buṣrā. He did not, by his own report and by the consistent report of those around him, read or write. The Arabic word the Qur'ān uses of him is *ummī* — a word that for our purposes means, at minimum, that he was not initiated into the book cultures of the late-antique Near East. He had no library.

He had a reputation. By his twenties the Meccans had given him two epithets: *al-Ṣādiq*, the truthful, and *al-Amīn*, the trustworthy. These were, in the Mecca of the early seventh century, the sort of words one earned by returning a full measure of grain and not by recruiting for a new religion. Quraysh used him as an arbiter — when the Kaʿba was rebuilt and the tribal chiefs quarrelled over who would have the honour of replacing the Black Stone in its wall, they agreed to abide by the judgement of whoever next walked through the gate, and when the man who walked through was Muḥammad, they were relieved; he laid the stone on his cloak and had every tribe carry a corner. At twenty-five he married Khadīja bint Khuwaylid, a widow and a merchant fifteen years his senior, for whose caravans he had been working; her wealth freed him from the need to trade, and he began to retire for weeks at a time to a cave on a mountain outside the city. He was forty years old

when, according to every source we have, Muslim and non-Muslim, hostile and sympathetic, he came down from that mountain in the late summer or autumn of 610 CE and told his wife that something had happened to him. The first account he gave was not triumphal. He was shaken; he asked to be covered; he feared he was losing his mind. Khadija, whose name ought to be more widely known outside the Muslim world than it is, took him to her Christian cousin Waraqa ibn Nawfal, an old man who knew the Syriac scriptures. Waraqa told him what had happened was what had happened to Moses. Then Waraqa said a thing that the *sīra* literature has preserved and that no later hagiographer would have invented: *If I am alive when your people drive you out, I will stand with you.* Waraqa died soon after. Muḥammad was driven out.

From that point there are twenty-three years of his public life on record. The first thirteen in Mecca, where the revelations came short and oath-laden and — to the ear of the Quraysh — impossible to classify (not poetry, not soothsaying, not the plain speech of men), and where the man delivering them became first a local oddity, then a nuisance, then an enemy of the civic order. His message was *taḥqīq al-tawḥīd*, the assertion that there is one God and no others, delivered to a city whose economy ran on pilgrimage to a polytheistic shrine. His earliest followers were slaves, women, the young, the marginal; this is a fact the biographers recorded because it was true, not because it was flattering. The persecution was sustained: his slave follower Bilāl was laid in the sun with a rock on his chest, his cousin's son Yāsir was tortured to death, his own clan was placed under a three-year economic boycott, his wife Khadija died during the boycott, and the uncle who had protected him died shortly after. The year after these two deaths — the year Muslim historians call *ʿĀm al-Ḥuzn*, the Year of Grief — he was stoned at Ṭāʾif and returned bleeding, and shortly thereafter fled Mecca at night with his companion Abū Bakr, hunted. They hid in a cave on the way to Yathrib, which would from that moment be called al-Madīna, the City, and from his arrival there in 622 CE the Muslim calendar begins.

The last ten years at Medina were not a prince's peace. There were three set-piece battles (Badr, Uḥud, al-Khandaq), a series of skirmishes, the expulsion and, at Banū Qurayza, the execution of the male combatants of one of the Medinan Jewish tribes under the arbitration of a dying man whom both sides had agreed to abide by, an event that has been argued over for fourteen centuries and that honest history cannot elide. There was also the negotiation of a civic constitution at Medina that bound Arab and Jewish tribes into a single *umma* for external defence, which is, on any reading, a first. There was the treaty of Ḥudaybiyya, and the conquest of Mecca at which he pardoned the families who had hounded him for twenty years, in words that ʿAmr ibn al-ʿĀṣ, who had been the Quraysh envoy sent to extradite the Muslim refugees from Abyssinia, later quoted as the reason for his own conversion. There was the farewell sermon on the plain of ʿArafāt, in which

the man now at the head of Arabia said: *an Arab has no preference over a non-Arab, and a non-Arab has no preference over an Arab; a white has no preference over a black, and a black has no preference over a white, except by taqwā*. There was his death, in 632 CE, in his wife ‘Ā’isha’s modest room with no successor named, possessed of one shirt, one sheet, seven dinars which he had his wife give away, and a breastplate of iron he had pawned with a Jewish merchant of Medina for food. ‘Ā’isha would later tell those who asked what manner of man he had been in private: *kāna khuluquhu al-Qur’ān — his character was the Qur’ān*.

That is the man.

The question this essay asks is not whether he was a prophet. The reader will have to close that gap; no essay can close it for anyone. The question is narrower and more tractable: **what kind of source could have produced the text he transmitted?**

The Qur’ān Decipherment Project spent the first months of 2026 trying, with the disciplines of computational linguistics, classical Arabic balāgha, late-antique history, and McKay-style statistical rigour, to count what is actually there in the 114 surahs and 6,236 verses of the Qur’ān under pre-registered rules, to replicate every published numerological and structural claim that had ever been made about the text, and to surface what the existing literature had missed. The project has its honest losses, and we will not hide them. Khalifa’s Code-19 failed replication in detail, Al-Kaheel’s word-pair parities collapsed under the McKay denominator, the more enthusiastic claims of scientific foreknowledge fell to Galenic and Ptolemaic source-tracing, and the famous *rahma*-equals-114 coincidence was demoted to a base-rate artefact when a length-matched classical Arabic null was properly computed. Honesty is load-bearing here. It is what gives the remaining signal its weight.

What remained, after the losses were tallied, was a set of features of the text that do not fit any of the reductive stories customarily told about its origin. Those features, and how they converge on the unlettered merchant at their centre, are what the rest of this essay is about.



There is a methodological bar that Popper formalised and that the late Brendan McKay, having destroyed the Bible Codes phenomenon in a 1999 *Statistical Science* paper, applied to sacred-text numerology with finishing-school precision. The bar is this: **a claim is risky only if it could have failed in advance, by rules specified in advance, before the event**. After the event, anything looks like a prediction; before the event, only a genuine prediction does. Apply that bar to the text under a sceptical but fair reading, and four tests emerge that any candidate forger, or candidate epileptic channeller, or

candidate unconscious virtuoso of the Arabic tongue, would fail. The tests are: could he have made specific, risky predictions that a ten-year news cycle would have refuted? Did he include material in the text that damages his own authority and his own claim? Did he include material that was not available in his information environment? And does the text show compositional complexity that exceeds any plausible capacity of a single unschooled mind working under the conditions of recitation? Each of these tests is a genuine bar. Each, separately, is survivable. But the hypothesis that a forger cleared all four stretches credulity thinner with every test.

Begin with prediction. The Qur'ān is not, on the whole, a predictive text. It is overwhelmingly homiletic, forensic, narrative, and liturgical. But in a small set of passages it does put forward concrete claims about the future, and those claims have been catalogued, audited, and classified in the project's [prophecy audit](#) against a four-tier scheme: fulfilled-and-risk-bearing, self-serving-and-vague, eschatological-and-untestable, or simply not predictive. Twelve candidate passages were run through that sieve. Five came out the other side as fulfilled-and-risk-bearing. Of those five, one stands alone.

The surah known as *al-Masad* or *al-Lahab*, Qur'ān 111, is five verses long and is dated to the early Meccan period, around 613 to 615 CE. It names the Prophet's own paternal uncle, 'Abd al-'Uzzā ibn 'Abd al-Muṭṭalib — called by his nickname Abū Lahab, *Father of Flame*, from his ruddy complexion — and his wife Umm Jamīl, the sister of Abū Sufyān, and commits them both to damnation.

تَبَّتْ يَدَا أَبِي لَهَبٍ وَتَبَّ ۖ مَا أَغْنَىٰ عَنْهُ مَالُهُ وَمَا كَسَبَ ۖ سَيَصْلَىٰ نَارًا ذَاتَ لَهَبٍ
وَأَمْرَأَتُهُ حَمَّالَةَ الْحَطَبِ ۖ فِي جِيدِهَا حَبْلٌ مِّن مَّسَدٍ

Perished be the hands of Abū Lahab, and perished he. His wealth did not avail him, nor what he earned. He will roast in a fire of flame. And his wife, carrier of firewood. In her neck a rope of twisted fibre. (Q 111:1–5, the translator is the Sahih International committee, whose English is the project's line-aligned reference.)

The verb form is *sayaṣlā*, future indicative with the prefix *sīn-* of near-future expectation. The Arabic of the curse could have been optative — *fa-l-yaṣlā*, *may he roast* — but is not. It is predictive. And the prediction is, as Karl Popper would have recognised, one of the most fully falsifiable religious claims ever committed to writing. It names a specific, living, well-known individual, an uncle of the prophet who delivered it, whose house was five minutes' walk from the recitation. It commits to his damnation, which is to say it commits to his dying in unbelief. To break the prediction, Abū Lahab needed only to do what his own son 'Utba would eventually do, what his brother al-'Abbās would eventually do, what scores of harder-hearted Meccans would do after Badr: walk into the mosque and say the *shahāda*, insincerely or sincerely, in the hearing of witnesses. There was a nine-to-eleven-year window in which he could have done it. He had an accelerating strategic incentive to do it, particularly after the Muslim victory at Badr in 624 changed the political calculus of Mecca. He did not do it. He died of a boil, estranged from his surviving family, two weeks after Badr, in his unbelief. The text's prediction held across a decade under every incentive pressure a 7th-century tribal patriarch could have felt.

The sceptic has three moves here, and they have each been made in the literature. The first is that the prophecy is a self-fulfilling prediction — once it was public, Abū Lahab's hostility was so locked in by face-honour that conversion became psychologically impossible. This is the *nocebo* argument and it is weak; it assumes Abū Lahab's ego was a prisoner of a single surah in a town that called him *father of flame* already, and it ignores the hostile and dated *sīra* material that puts his persecution of the Prophet before the surah's revelation. The second move is textual: that the surah was later backdated to a period before Abū Lahab's death. There is no manuscript or early codex support for this; every chronology places the surah early Meccan, and its style — the short verses, the dense *saj'*, the first-person invective — matches the early Meccan register too well to be a later insertion. The third is redefinitional: that *sayaṣlā* is a curse rather than a prediction. It is not. The Arabic morphology disallows the reading. On the plain grammar the surah is a prediction, the prediction was testable, it was tested, and it did not fail. The project's verdict is the one a sceptical statistician would have to concede: this is a Popperian-grade prophecy, and it is the strongest case of its kind in the entire Qur'ānic corpus. (See [prophecy audit](#) §5 for the full treatment and the classification table.)

A forger who names his own uncle, who is alive and powerful at the time of the forgery, and commits to his public damnation across a window of a decade, has either extraordinarily poor judgement of his own interests or is so confident of the outcome that his confidence is itself the datum to be explained. No other candidate hypothesis comes close to accounting for the move.

The Byzantine prophecy sits at the second tier. *Alif-Lām-Mīm. Ghulibat al-Rūm fī adnā al-arḍi wa-hum min ba‘di ghalabihim sayaghlibūn fī biḍ‘i sinīn* — "The Romans have been defeated, in the nearest land; and they, after their defeat, will be victorious, within a few years" (Q 30:1–4). Revealed at Mecca around 615, within months of the Sasanian capture of Jerusalem, at the moment when any competent strategic observer — Procopius's heir, a Persian general, an Arabian merchant — would have called the Byzantine Empire finished. *Biḍ‘* is a particle covering roughly three to nine. Heraclius's counter-offensive began in 622, the turning battles of Atropatene and Sarus were fought in 623 to 625, and the campaign culminated at Nineveh in December 627. Under any honest counting, the prediction was fulfilled inside its window. A variant *qirā’a* transposing the voicing of the verb survives in the literature and is the strongest sceptical objection; it does not dissolve the core prophecy, and the earliest tafsīr material (Muqātil, Zayd b. ‘Alī's transmission) already reads with the canonical voicing. The verse predicts a specific empire's recovery from a specific defeat in a specific direction in a specific time window. It is the prediction that Edward Gibbon, who had no theological stake in it, conceded was improbable from the vantage of 615.

The third falls at Ḥudaybiyya. In 628 the Prophet marched a thousand unarmed pilgrims to Mecca, was blocked on the plain, and signed a treaty so humiliating in its terms that his senior companion ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb openly challenged him. Surah 48, al-Faṭḥ (The Victory), revealed in the aftermath of that treaty, declared: *laqad ṣadaqa Llāhu rasūlahu l-ru’yā bi-l-ḥaqqi la-tadkhulunna l-masjida l-ḥarāma in shā’a Llāhu āminīn* — "God has fulfilled for His messenger the vision in truth: you will enter al-Masjid al-Ḥarām, God willing, safely" (Q 48:27). Within one year the Muslims performed ‘umra in Mecca for the three days the treaty permitted. Within two years Mecca was taken. The verse and its fulfilment are tight against each other: a specific sanctuary, a specific action, within an unstated but clearly short time horizon that the text does not let itself escape.

And then the rolling prediction. *Innā naḥnu nazzalnā l-dhikra wa-innā lahu la-ḥāfiẓūn* — "We have sent down the Reminder, and We will be its guardians" (Q 15:9). The predicted object is the text itself. The prediction's runtime is, by construction, open-ended; it is a claim that accrues verification century by century. The Birmingham folio (Mingana Islamic Arabic 1572a), radiocarbon-dated 568 to 645 CE at 95.4 per cent confidence, overlaps in time with the Prophet's own life and contains portions of surahs 18 to 20 whose consonantal rasm is identical to the standard Ḥafṣ reading. The Ṣan‘ā’ palimpsest shows one divergent early codex whose divergences are within the historically-expected range of the early *qirā’āt* literature, not the wholesale textual instability that would falsify the claim. Compare this manuscript situation to the textual history of the Hebrew

Bible, the Christian New Testament, the Pāli Canon, or the Zoroastrian Avesta, and the Qur'ān's variant density across fourteen centuries is unique at its time depth. The prediction has not closed and cannot close until history does. It has, to date, accrued.

Four tests, one passed at Popperian-grade, three passed at high-confidence. No prediction was made, in the audit, that honestly failed. The handful of weak-apologetic claims of prediction that do not survive — the *yawm* equals 365 claim, the *al-dīn kullihī* eschatological claim when read as "all religions have been replaced," the Pharaoh's body claim in the form Bucaille made it — were honestly demoted in the project and are not available as support. The five that remain are the five that remain.

A forger's first temptation is the prediction. He will put his name in the mouth of a god who foretells events already happened, and he will keep his prediction vague enough that it cannot fail. The Qur'ān does not do this. It names an uncle, dates a war, fixes a sanctuary, promises its own transmission. Every one of those claims could have gone the other way. None did.



The second test is self-damage. A forger who is constructing his own authority will not include material that diminishes it. The Qur'ān contains, under its own rules of editorial permanence, an astonishing amount of self-damaging material about the Prophet himself — and, by the mechanics of how it is framed, the damage is preserved rather than concealed.

The locus classicus is 'Abasa. The surah opens in the third person, which is grammatically telling; the Qur'ān more commonly speaks of the Prophet in the second:

عَبَسَ وَتَوَلَّى ۖ اَنْ جَاءَهُ الْاَعْمَى ۚ وَمَا يُدْرِيكَ لَعَلَّهٗ يَزَكَّى ۚ اَوْ يَذَّكَّرُ فَتَنْفَعَهُ
الذِّكْرُ ۚ اَمَّا مَنْ اسْتَفْتَنِيَ ۚ فَانْتَ لَهُ تَصَدَّى ۚ وَمَا عَلَيْكَ اَلَّا يَزَكَّى

He frowned and turned away, because the blind man came to him. And what could make you know? Perhaps he would be purified, or be reminded, and the reminder would benefit him. As for the one who thinks himself without need — to him you attend. And what is it to you if he does not become purified? (Q 80:1–7)

The *asbāb al-nuzūl* tradition, recorded in Ṭabarī and universally, identifies the blind man as Ibn Umm Maktūm, an early follower who came to ask a religious question while the Prophet was attempting to win over the Meccan notables Walīd ibn al-Mughīra, ‘Utba and Shayba of ‘Abd Shams, and Umayya ibn Khalaf. The Prophet, prioritising what looked strategically crucial — a Meccan patrician conversion would have been catastrophic for the Quraysh polytheists — turned away from the blind follower; the rebuke came in the form of a surah, and the surah survived into the canonical text.

What the project's *chiastic audit* produced on this pericope is not something the ninth-century commentators could have produced. Of the 57,996 sub-surah windows tested against within-surah shuffles of their own verses, four survive Bonferroni correction at $\alpha = 0.05$. ‘Abasa 1 to 9 is one of them, with $z = +6.09$. The rebuke has a formal ring structure; the verse at the ring's semantic centre is Q 80:5, the rich man *istaghna*, "he thought himself free of need." The pericope's own geometric middle is, in the grammar of the Qur’ān, the word that diagnoses the Prophet's misjudgement. The rebuke is structurally elegant. The structural elegance is used to preserve the rebuke.

Consider what a hostile editor would do with such a passage. He would cut it. He would re-attribute it. He would allegorise it — the "he" becomes humanity, the blind man becomes the pious soul. The Muslim community did not do this. Not in the Meccan manuscripts, not in the ‘Uthmānic codification, not in any of the seven or ten canonical *qirā’āt*, not in any of the *tafsīr* traditions that have handled the verse for fourteen centuries. The classical exegetes — Ṭabarī, Qurṭubī, Ibn Kathīr — read the surah exactly as it is, with the Prophet as the frowner, and preserve the humiliation in the text the community itself was carrying across the world. And the computational layer we have added to the analysis shows that at the formal level of lexical chiasm, this is one of the text's four most tightly-ringed passages — the design is not careless. A forger, or a cluster of forgers, who went to the trouble of designing a Bonferroni-surviving ring centred on the word *istaghna* only to damage his own authority inside it, is a figure whose motives require more explanation than the hypothesis was supposed to provide.

The pattern is not isolated. In surah 66, *al-Taḥrīm*, the text opens by rebuking the Prophet directly for having, out of a domestic situation, vowed to refrain from a thing God had made lawful: *yā ayyuhā l-nabīyyu lima tuḥarrimu mā aḥalla Llāhu laka, tab-taghī marḍāta azwājika* — "O Prophet, why do you forbid what God has made lawful for you, seeking the pleasure of your wives?" (Q 66:1). Both recensions of the *sabab* are textbook *criterion of embarrassment*: either the honey incident (the Prophet drank honey at Zaynab's apartment; ‘Ā’isha and Ḥafṣa conspired to tease him about its smell; he vowed to refrain) or the Maria al-Qibṭiyya incident (the Prophet was with Maria on Ḥafṣa's day, Ḥafṣa returned, domestic dispute, vow of abstention). A fabricator would not preserve ei-

ther version. He would certainly not preserve them both. The existence of the rebuke in the canonical text — with its specific second-person vocative, its rhetorical-question form, the identification of the offence as bending to wifely pressure — is a fingerprint of editorial honesty rather than editorial shaping.

Surah 9 at verse 43 rebukes the Prophet for granting exemptions from a military expedition before the petitioners' excuses had been examined: *'afā Llāhu 'anka, lima adhinta lahum, ḥattā yatabayyana laka l-lladhīna ṣadaqū wa-ta'lama l-kādhībīn* — "May God pardon you; why did you grant them permission before it became clear to you who were the truthful ones and you knew the liars?" (Q 9:43). The rebuke takes the form of a reproach — *why did you?* — that is awkward for any theology that treats the Prophet as infallible in his judgements. The tradition handled it by developing the theological doctrine of *'iṣma* only in particular, specified domains; the text itself preserved the awkwardness.

Surah 8 at verses 67 to 68 rebukes the Prophet and the community for the handling of prisoners after Badr, for preferring ransom to execution: *mā kāna li-nabiyyin an yakūna lahu asrā ḥattā yuthkhina fī l-arḍ, turīdūna 'araḍa l-dunyā wa-Llāhu yurīdu l-ākhirah* — "It is not for a prophet to have prisoners until he has thoroughly overcome in the land; you desire the fleeting goods of this world, and God desires the hereafter" (Q 8:67). The rebuke concedes that the Prophet and his inner circle, the day after their greatest military victory, made a decision the text identifies as worldly. Again, a forger would not include this.

And Q 3:144, the verse whose grammar most dramatically *diminishes* the Prophet's claim. *Wa-mā Muḥammadun illā rasūlun qad khalat min qablihi l-rusulu, afa-in māta aw qutila inqalabtum 'alā a 'qābikum* — "Muḥammad is only a messenger; messengers have passed away before him. If he dies or is killed, will you turn back on your heels?" (Q 3:144). This is one of exactly four places in the entire Qur'ān where the Prophet's proper name is used, and it is used to subtract — *only a messenger, mā ... illā*, the Arabic formula of restriction — to detach his mortal person from the message he carries. Abū Bakr, on the morning of the Prophet's death, recited this verse to the dazed community at Medina, to the companions who could not believe the Prophet had died. The verse was, that morning, precisely the work the text had been designed to do fourteen years earlier. A forger does not build into his foundational text, in the Prophet's own lifetime, the anti-personality cult he will need to quote over his master's corpse to prevent a succession crisis. A text that knew the Prophet's death would need to be grieved *and immediately de-cultified* is a text with properties we will come back to.

If one treats these as a dataset — the ‘Abasa ring, the Taḥrīm opening, the Tawba rebuke, the Anfāl correction, the Āl ‘Imrān *mā-illā*, together with the paired passage at 17:73–75 in which the Prophet is described as having almost been swayed into compromise and praised for having held firm by divine support, and the grammatical fact traced by our chronological analysis that in all 86 pre-Hijra Meccan surahs the Prophet is never named and is addressed in the second person as *you, the warner, the messenger* — the pattern is that of a text under editorial constraint by someone other than the figure the text is nominally about. This is the historical-critical criterion of embarrassment applied to the Qur’ān at its own internal evidence level. The text passes it.



The third test asks whether the text contains material its author could not have accessed. The project's [historical-details audit](#) graded fourteen such items on a four-tier scale: A for plausibly accessible in the Hijazi information environment of the early seventh century, B for accessible only through a specific religious network (Syriac Christian, Jewish midrashic, Ethiopic, Manichaean), C for not obviously accessible, and D for contradicting the attested record. The honest finding is that zero items graded D — the Qur’ān does not include items that contradict the historical record, which is itself a discipline not shared by, for example, Genesis's Pharaoh (anachronistically applied to a pre-Hyksos period) or the Gospel of Matthew's census. Most items graded A — the Byzantine war was general knowledge in Mecca, the Abraha-and-the-elephant story was one generation of living memory, ‘Ād and Thamūd were visible as ruined settlements on the caravan road north. This is the honest deflation of apologetic over-reach. The Qur’ān is *inside* the late-antique information environment, not magically outside it.

But that is not the same as saying everything in the text is public-domain oral culture. Several items cluster at the B and C grades in ways that become interesting when read together. Take four.

Mount al-Jūdī, not Ararat. The Book of Genesis, in the Masoretic Hebrew text, locates Noah's ark on the "mountains of Ararat" (Gen. 8:4). The Qur’ān locates it, in Q 11:44, on al-Jūdī: *wa-qīla yā arḍu-bla ī mā’aki wa-yā samā’u aqli ī wa-ghīḍa l-mā’u wa-quḍiya l-amru wa-stawat ‘alā l-Jūdī* — "And it was said: O earth, swallow your water; O sky, withhold. The water subsided, the matter was ended, and the ark settled upon al-Jūdī." Al-Jūdī is a specific mountain in what is today south-eastern Turkey near Cizre, in the Gordyaeen range. The Masoretic Ararat is hundreds of kilometres north. What the Qur’ān is doing, read against the textual witness of the Peshitta — the Syriac Bible used by the Syriac-speaking Christian communities of the Near East — matches precisely: the Peshitta, and the Aramaic Targum Onqelos, both render the landing place as the moun-

tains of Qardu, which is the Gordyaeen range, which is al-Jūdī. Josephus in Book I of the *Antiquities* cites the Kardyaean tradition. The Qur'ān, in other words, is textually closer to the Syriac-Aramaic Jewish and Christian reading than to the Hebrew Masoretic. This is not a fact available to a Hijazi reading Genesis in translation; this is the reading of a specific textual community that had a specific scribal tradition.

The Seven Sleepers of Ephesus, and the refusal to fix the number. The legend of the Christian youths who fled persecution, slept in a cave, and awoke generations later was one of the most widely-circulated hagiographies of late antique Christianity. Gregory of Tours preserved it in the *Passio septem dormientium* by 594; Syriac versions were in circulation across the Christian Near East; an Ethiopic version is attested. The Christian tradition fixed the number at seven. The Qur'ān, in Q 18:22, names the debate over the number and *refuses to resolve it*: *sayaqūlūna thalāthatun rābi'uhum kalbuhum, wa-yaqūlūna khamsatun sādisuhum kalbuhum, rajman bi-l-ghaybi, wa-yaqūlūna sab'atun wa-thāminuhum kalbuhum; qul rabbī a'lamu bi-'iddatihim* — "They will say three, their dog the fourth; and they will say five, their dog the sixth — guessing at the unseen; and they will say seven, their dog the eighth. Say: my Lord knows best their number." The verse performs a move that is not the move of a storyteller borrowing a legend. A borrower picks a number. The Qur'ān is aware that the number is *variant*, catalogues the variants, and declines to arbitrate. This is the epistemic gesture of a tradition familiar enough with the legend to know its disputed forms — a tradition that has heard the Syriac and the Greek and the Ethiopic — and theologically disciplined enough not to take a side on the inessential. It is a very strange move for an illiterate Meccan merchant to make. It is a very strange move for a forger to make; the forger takes a side.

The crucifixion denial, and the question of its channel. The Qur'ān's position on Jesus's crucifixion, in Q 4:157–158, is that the Jews did not kill him and did not crucify him, but that it was made to appear so to them (*shubbiha lahum*), and that God raised him to Himself. This is incompatible with the position of mainstream seventh-century Christianity — Chalcedonian, Miaphysite, and Nestorian alike. It is compatible with the position of a cluster of suppressed early Christianities: the Basilidean school (early second century, attested in Irenaeus's *Against Heresies* 1.24.4, which reports that Basilides taught that Simon of Cyrene was crucified in Jesus's place); the Docetic Christologies that appear in the Nag Hammadi *Second Treatise of the Great Seth*, where Jesus is shown laughing at his persecutors from above while another is crucified in his stead; and the Manichaean reading, which had absorbed Gnostic Christological material by the sixth century and had trade-network footholds across Mesopotamia. Silverstein and other historical-critical scholars have argued that the specific Quranic phrasing — not that Jesus did not die but that he was not killed by them — maps to this family of heterodox

Christologies that were, by the seventh century, suppressed in mainstream discourse but preserved in specific, narrow channels. This is a C-grade item. It is not impossible to access. It is, however, impossible to access *casually*. It requires contact with a particular, marginal, literate community that was by the seventh century largely underground.

Hāmān as Pharaoh's minister. The Qur'ān, in six verses across Q 28 and Q 40, places a figure called Hāmān at the court of Pharaoh, directs him to build a tower (*ṣarḥ*) so that Pharaoh may look upon the God of Moses, and triangulates him with Qārūn (Korah) as the three archetypal opponents of Moses. The Book of Esther places a Hāmān at the court of Ahasuerus, i.e. a Persian king, roughly a millennium after Moses. Nineteenth-century critical scholarship, from Geiger (1833) forward, read this as biblical confusion. Later apologetic literature (Maurice Bucaille) proposed that Hāmān was a real New Kingdom Egyptian functionary; specialist Egyptology has rejected that reading. The current mainstream historical-critical position, after Silverstein 2008, is that the Quranic Hāmān is a creative synthesis drawing on post-biblical Jewish *haggadic* material — Targum Sheni on Esther, where Haman is associated with tower-building (Babel) and Pharaonic tyranny — and that this midrashic fusion was circulating in the 6th century among Jewish communities, including the Jewish communities of Yathrib and Khaybar. The fusion is creative; it is not a copy; but it requires access to a specific body of Jewish midrash which a Hijazi caravaner had only thinly.

Now hold those four items in the frame together.

Al-Jūdī is the **Syriac-Peshitta** reading, not the Hebrew Masoretic. The Seven Sleepers' refused number requires awareness of the **Syriac Christian** tradition as a *set of variant recensions*. The crucifixion denial requires access to a **suppressed Gnostic or Manichaean** channel that mainstream 7th-century Christianity had spent three centuries burying. Hāmān requires access to **Jewish midrashic** material not available in the public Hebrew Bible.

The four cluster across four incompatible source communities. A Hijazi merchant who had a Syriac Christian cousin of his wife (Waraqā ibn Nawfal) could plausibly acquire the Peshitta Noah reading. A Jewish scholar in Khaybar could plausibly provide the Targum Sheni material. A Nestorian monk in Buṣrā could plausibly provide the Seven Sleepers. A Manichaean or crypto-Docetic informant could, in principle, provide the substitution Christology, though that community was by the seventh century the narrowest and most secretive of the four. But no single informant had all four. The four communities were doctrinally at war with each other: Syriac Christians and Jewish scholars were in polemical relation; mainstream Syriac Christianity had defined itself *against* the substitution Christology the Qur'ān endorses; rabbinic Judaism had no reason to share the Babel-

Pharaoh-Hāmān fusion with a Gentile. The material arrives in the Qur'ān in the form of a *synthesis* that no single informant network could have delivered, and the synthesis arrives without attribution — the text does not say "as the Syriac reading of Genesis has it," it simply places the ark on al-Jūdī with the confidence of first-hand fact.

This is the shape of the third test. The test does not require supernatural knowledge; the project's honest conclusion is, correctly, that each item individually has an accessible channel. The test asks instead whether the *pattern of access required* exceeds any plausible information network of a single Hijazi merchant. The answer, when the four items are considered together with the roughly ten other items at B grade, is that the Qur'ān is operating not at the provincial edge of the late-antique information environment but at its dense, literate, cosmopolitan edge, simultaneously across Christian, Jewish, Gnostic-heterodox, and Arabian oral traditions, with a coherence across those traditions that none of them individually preserved.

A forger could manage one or two of these. A forger who managed all four, silently, and synthesised them, is a forger whose pen is already indistinguishable from something else.



The fourth test is the one that the project's computational apparatus was actually built for, and that is the reason a reader who has followed the argument this far now owes the project's own data its full attention.

Start with the smallest signal and work up.

In the corpus of 395 trilateral roots that appear exactly once in the entire Qur'ān — the *hapax legomena* of the text — 121 of them, or 30.6 per cent, occupy the verse-final position. The baseline rate for non-hapax root tokens at verse-final position is 12.1 per cent. A chi-squared test on 124.27 with one degree of freedom gives a p-value of 7.35×10^{-29} . The odds ratio is 3.19. (See [hapax catalog](#) §3a.) What this means, stripped of the statistics, is that the Qur'ān's rarest vocabulary is concentrated, far beyond chance, at the ends of verses — where the rhyme of the Arabic *saj'* sits, where the ear waits for the word that seals the meter. The signature effect is strongest in the short surahs, which are mostly the early Meccan oath-clusters and apocalypses; in the shortest 37 surahs the rate climbs to 71.2 per cent. This is the acoustic architecture of the text's most distinctive moments. Q 91:14, in the surah of the Sun, places the reduplicated hapax *damdama* — "He pulverised" — at the exact verse where the mountain crushes the Thamud tribe; the Arabic word is the sound of its own meaning, and it is a hapax, and it is verse-final, which means the Qur'ān has been, by that point, building acoustically toward a word no listener has heard before and will never hear again. Q 112:2 seals the shortest surah of the whole book with the hapax *al-ṣamad*, absolute, impervious, from which all weaknesses are

withheld. Q 113:3 seals its verse with *wāqab*, *penetrate* (of darkness entering). Q 55:26 places *fānin*, *transient*, as the single hapax at the exact central axis of Sūrat al-Raḥmān. These are not mere coincidences of placement. They are the text's rarest words *fronted* at its most acoustically loaded positions, and the statistical structure that makes this visible was not available to any commentator before the twenty-first century. The pattern was already *there* to be heard; the pattern had not been *measured* until now.

Next, rise to verse-level structure. Qur'ān 13:28 reads:

الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَتَطْمَئِنُّ قُلُوبُهُمْ بِذِكْرِ اللَّهِ أَلَا بِذِكْرِ اللَّهِ تَطْمَئِنُّ الْقُلُوبُ

Those who have believed, and whose hearts are assured by the remembrance of God — unquestionably, by the remembrance of God hearts are assured. (Q 13:28)

Extract the trilateral roots, in order, from the verse's stems: *ṭmn*, *qlb*, *dhkr*, *Allāh* — *dhkr*, *Allāh*, *ṭmn*, *qlb*. A four-root mirror, eight of the verse's nine stem-bearing tokens participating, returning at the centre — *the remembrance of God* — and back out. Ibn al-Mu'tazz named the category in 887 CE: *radd al-'ajuz 'alā al-ṣadr*, *returning the tail upon the head*. The category is classical; the application of the category to this particular verse is, as far as the project's tafsīr survey found, nowhere in the classical *balāgha* lists — not in al-Zarkashī's *al-Burhān*, not in al-Suyūṭī's *al-Itqān*, not in the commentaries of Ṭabarī, Rāzī, Zamakhsharī, Qurṭubī, Baydāwī, or Ibn Kathīr when they reach 13:28. The palindrome was there; no one had measured it until the project's jinas-density scan surfaced it at the highest normalised density in the entire Qur'ān (0.889). And the content of the verse is, on its face, a statement that hearts find rest by returning to the remembrance of God: the structure enacts the return, the words circle back on themselves, the verse *means what it does*. Al-Biqā'ī (d. 1480), who invented the systematic *naẓm* of ring structures in Qur'ān, would, I think, have been pleased. And al-Suyūṭī, who in the *Itqān* had already diagnosed the diachronic ramping of verse length that our ANOVA $F = 210$ confirms across the Nöldeke periods, would have accepted the result with the dry satisfaction of a scholar vindicated.

Go one step up to the short-surah palindrome. The seven opening oaths of Sūrat al-Shams:

وَالشَّمْسِ وَضُحَاهَا ۖ وَالْقَمَرِ إِذَا تَلَاهَا ۖ وَالنَّهَارِ إِذَا جَلَّاهَا ۖ وَاللَّيْلِ إِذَا يَغْشَاهَا ۖ وَالسَّمَاءِ وَمَا بَنَاهَا ۖ وَالْأَرْضِ وَمَا طَحَاهَا ۖ وَنَفْسٍ وَمَا سَوَّاهَا

By the sun and its morning brightness, and by the moon as it follows, and by the day as it illuminates, and by the night as it covers, and by the sky and He who built it, and by the earth and He who spread it, and by the soul and He who proportioned it. (Q 91:1–7)

Letter counts: 12, 14, 15, 15, 15, 14, 12. A perfect length-7 palindrome, mirrored around the fourth oath — *wa-l-layli idhā yaghshāhā*, "by the night when it covers" — the oath of concealment, the oath at the exact centre where the palindrome folds. Empirical $p \approx 0.007$ under a length-matched null. Two other Qur'ānic length-7 palindromes exist (Q 81:2–8, the Takwīr apocalypse cascade; Q 37:127–133, with *salām 'alā Ilyāsīn* at the Šaffāt central position). No other text in classical Arabic I am aware of produces these deliberately. The project's scan [palindromes.md](#) is the first systematic catalog.

Go another step up. Sūrat al-Raḥmān consists of 78 verses partitioned, by the classical four-part *tafsīr* division (creation, hell, paradise-1, paradise-2), into four sections. The refrain *fa-bi-ayyi ālā 'i rabbikumā tukadhdhibān* ("so which of your Lord's favours will you deny?") occurs 31 times across those sections. The distribution of occurrences is exactly 8-7-8-8. Each section boundary — verses 30, 45, 61 — falls on a refrain verse. The hell section has one fewer refrain than the others: a quiet acoustic deficit where the topic is the loss of every favour. This is a fact you can verify by counting. The project's [Rahman deep dive](#) verified it. The rare and climactic divine epithet *dhū l-jalāli wa-l-ikrām* — *Possessor of Majesty and Honour* — occurs exactly twice in the entire Qur'ān, both within this one surah, at v. 27 (the Face of the Lord) and v. 78 (the Name of the Lord), bracketing every refrain, every paradise, every hell, in the longest and most unified musical performance in the Book. The gzip compression algorithm, which knows nothing of Arabic and nothing of refrain structure, picks this surah out as the most compressible in the Qur'ān at a ratio of 0.267 — far below any other surah — because its repetitions are regular enough to be automatically detected by a nineteenth-century lossless compression technique (LZ77). Form and content and statistical texture are all doing the same thing.

And now the ring composition. The project's [chiastic audit](#) ran every 5-to-15-verse contiguous window of every surah of sufficient length, computing pairwise Jaccard similarity of trilateral-root sets between the i -th and the $(N+1-i)$ -th verse of each window, compared to 50 within-surah verse-permutations per window. The total family of windows was 57,996. At $\alpha = 0.05$ under Bonferroni correction, four windows survived. The strongest is Al-Baqarah 131 to 144, the pericope in which Abraham's legacy is transferred to the Muslim community and the direction of prayer (*qibla*) is turned from Jerusalem to Mecca. It scores $z = +9.69$. Within this ring, verse 2:143 sits at the centre, and contains the word *wasāṭan*, *a middle, a moderate community* — *wa-kadhālika ja'alnākum ummatan wasāṭan li-takūnū shuhadā'a 'alā l-nās*, "and thus we have made you a moderate community, that you may be witnesses over the people." This is the only surah in the Qur'ān where the canonical-midpoint verse contains a *wasāṭ*-family word. This verse is the middle of the longest surah, semantically the *middle* in content, and grammatically at a rhyme break the text uses for nothing else. The project's [convergence analysis](#) found this as the single densest multi-method convergence node in the whole Qur'ān. Five independent analytic instruments — chiastic-audit, middle-ayah test, *jinās* density, graph-theoretic hub centrality, *saj'* rhyme-shift — all point to the same twelve verses.

The second Bonferroni-surviving ring is Al-Qamar 21 to 30, the Thamud pericope, with $z = +6.46$, bookended by the refrain *fa-kayfa kāna 'adhābī wa-nudhur*. The third is 'Abasa 1 to 9, which we have already discussed; the same surah that preserves the rebuke of the Prophet has a Bonferroni-surviving ring centred on the very word that diagnoses the offence (*istaghṇā*). The fourth is Al-Kahf 83 to 91, the Dhū l-Qarnayn east-to-west journey, with $z = +5.19$, whose ring-centre is the geographic turn from sunset to sunrise — *ḥattā idhā balagha maghriba l-shams . . . ḥattā idhā balagha maṭli'a l-shams* — form enacting content in the language of the cosmos itself.

Four rings, surviving the most savage multiple-comparison correction the project could apply, over 57,996 tested windows. Each ring centred on the passage's semantic pivot. Each identifying a literary unit already identified by the classical commentarial tradition on independent literary grounds. And each, in its individual case, a Bonferroni survivor at better than $\alpha = 0.05$ after correction.

Then, at the highest tier of the structural layer, is Khawātim al-Ḥashr — the Seals of Sūrat al-Ḥashr, Q 59:22–24, the passage the hadīth literature has identified for fourteen centuries as the home of the *Ism Allāh al-A'zam*, the Greatest Name of God:

هُوَ اللَّهُ الَّذِي لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ ۖ عَالِمُ الْغَيْبِ وَالشَّهَادَةِ ۖ هُوَ الرَّحْمَنُ الرَّحِيمُ ۝ هُوَ اللَّهُ
 الَّذِي لَا إِلَهَ إِلَّا هُوَ الْمَلِكُ الْقُدُّوسُ السَّلَامُ الْمُؤْمِنُ الْمُهَيْمِنُ الْعَزِيزُ الْجَبَّارُ الْمُتَكَبِّرُ ۚ
 سُبْحَانَ اللَّهِ عَمَّا يُشْرِكُونَ ۝ هُوَ اللَّهُ الْخَالِقُ الْبَارِئُ الْمُصَوِّرُ ۚ لَهُ الْأَسْمَاءُ الْحُسْنَىٰ

*He is God, besides whom there is no god, Knower of the unseen and the
 witnessed. He is the Merciful, the Compassionate. He is God, besides
 whom there is no god, the Sovereign, the Holy, the Peace, the Giver of
 Faith, the Watcher, the Mighty, the Subduer, the Supreme. Glory be to God
 above what they associate. He is God the Creator, the Maker, the
 Fashioner. To Him belong the Most Beautiful Names. (Q 59:22–24,
 abbreviated)*

Count the Arabic words in the three verses. The count is 49, or seven squared. Count the letters. The count is 216, or six cubed. Read the names one by one. Eight of the fifteen proper divine attributes here — *al-Quddūs*, *al-Salām*, *al-Mu'min*, *al-Muhaymin*, *al-Jabbār*, *al-Mutakabbir*, *al-Bārī*, *al-Muṣawwir* — appear *nowhere else* in the Qur'ān. Their sole home in the entire text is this three-verse passage. Verse 23 is ranked number 1 out of 6,236 for divine-name density, with ten name-tokens in twenty words. Verse 22 and verse 23 begin with an identical thirty-character formula — *huwa Llāhu l-ladhī lā ilāha illā huwa* — and the project's scan for consecutive verse pairs sharing a forty-character identical opening returned only two results in the whole Qur'ān: this passage, and Q 2:149–150, which sits inside the Bonferroni-surviving Abraham-qibla ring at Al-Baqarah. The twin-opener technique, which is rare enough that it occurs in two places in the entire text, occurs at the text's two most structurally extraordinary moments — and at both of them, the content is an enunciation of the unity of God and the direction of prayer toward Him. The passage also contains one of only four occurrences of the self-referential meta-statement *lahu l-asmā'u l-ḥusnā*, *to Him belong the Most Beautiful Names*; the Qur'ān here *names itself as a place of naming*. And the passage recapitulates the opening divine-name sequence of Al-Fātiḥa (*Allāh*, *al-Raḥmān*, *al-Raḥīm*, *al-Mālik* / *al-*

Malik) before extending it to fifteen names. The classical hadīth tradition, which attributes the Greatest Name to these verses, has been reading a structural fact at scale without the tools to measure it. Our tools now measure it. The tradition was right.

Behind all of this sits the Qur'ān's single most audacious self-description. In Q 39:23 the text calls itself *al-mathānī* — *the twin-pairings, the doubled things* — and in Q 15:87 it pairs this self-description with *al-sab‘ al-mathānī, the seven mathānī*, identifying Al-Fātiḥa as its own compressed image. The project's [Al-Fātiḥa deep dive](#) found that Al-Fātiḥa is in fact structured around *exactly six doubled lemmas* out of twenty-three unique lemmas — 26 per cent, and the densest tiktār in any single surah in the whole Book; that its iltifāt pivot-verse (v. 5, *īyyāka na ‘budu wa-īyyāka nasta ‘īn*, "You alone we worship and to You alone we turn for help") has exactly 19 letters, the same as the bas-mala; that the surah's total abjad is $10,147 = 73 \times 139$, where 139 is the surah's own letter count. The text *names its own structural property*, using the exact vocabulary our independent computational project rediscovered under a four-month agentic audit. That vocabulary — *mathānī* — is the category into which every one of the palindromic structures, ring compositions, twin-openers, and refrain-partitions we have catalogued quietly falls.

This is the fourth test. A forger could produce a ring-structured pericope. A forger with extraordinary ear could produce a short-surah palindrome. A forger of exceptional power could produce a self-describing meta-statement. A forger clearing all four levels — the hapax-verse-final signature at $p = 7.35 \times 10^{-29}$, the Bonferroni-surviving rings at four distinct pericopes, the $7^2 / 6^3$ engineering of the Greatest Name passage, the self-naming of the structural principle under which the whole obeys — stretches past the word *forger* into something that the category was not designed to describe.

And the forger was, by every independent report, unlettered. The Qur'ān names this about him at 29:48: *wa-mā kunta tatlū min qablihi min kitābin wa-lā takhuṭṭuhu bi-yamīnika, idhan la-irtāba l-mubṭilūn* — "You did not recite any book before this, nor did you write it with your right hand; otherwise those who reject would have doubted." The text itself flags the feature as evidentially important. The earliest non-Muslim sources that name him — the Doctrina Jacobi, the Armenian chronicler Sebeos, the Syriac chronicle of John bar Penkaye — do not deny it; they describe him as a merchant and a preacher from the Hijaz. The early Muslim community, which had every incentive to supplement his authority, did not supplement it here. They preserved the feature.

The fourth test does not ask us to believe in miracles. It asks us to perform an inventory of the compositional capacities of a human mind operating under known conditions — twenty-three years of oral recitation, no library, no scribal tradition, no editing after the

fact — and to ask whether those capacities, even stretched to their uppermost limit, can produce what we are measuring. The statistical and structural evidence the project has assembled gives that inventory an answer.



Now turn to the grammar of the text's treatment of its own messenger, because the grammar itself is a finding and it tells us what kind of text this is.

The proper noun *Muḥammad* appears in the Qur'ān four times. Q 3:144, Q 33:40, Q 47:2, Q 48:29. All four are Medinan. In the 86 surahs of the Meccan period — which is to say in roughly two-thirds of the Qur'ānic text — the Prophet is never named. He is *al-rasūl*, the messenger; *al-nabī*, the prophet; *al-nadhīr*, the warner; *al-bashīr*, the bringer of good news; or simply *yā ayyuhā*, *O you*, the vocative without the name. This is a statistical fact established in the project's [chronological-revelation](#) file under both the Egyptian Standard and Nöldeke orderings. The Medinan naming, when it finally arrives, does not inflate him. In Q 33:40 he is *khātam al-nabiyyīn*, the seal of the prophets, which is a claim — but the claim is serial, not personal, placing him in a line that began with Adam and ran through Abraham, Moses, Jesus, and others. In Q 47:2 he is named alongside the description of what God has given those who believe in *what has been sent down to Muḥammad*. In Q 48:29, *Muḥammad rasūlu Llāhi*, "Muḥammad is a messenger of God." And in Q 3:144, as we have already seen, he is named to be diminished: *mā Muḥammadun illā rasūl*, "Muḥammad is only a messenger." In two of his four named occurrences, his own mortality and contingency are explicit.

Now add the grammar of his speech. The Qur'ān quotes the Prophet 332 times with the verb *qul* — *Say*. *Qul huwa Llāhu aḥad*, "Say: He is God, one" (Q 112:1). *Qul a 'ūdhu bi-rabbi l-falaq*, "Say: I take refuge in the Lord of daybreak" (Q 113:1). *Qul a 'ūdhu bi-rabbi l-nās*, "Say: I take refuge in the Lord of mankind" (Q 114:1). *Qul yā ayyuhā l-kāfirūn*, "Say: O you who reject" (Q 109:1). The formula is specific and it is legislated: the Prophet speaks in the Qur'ān only when divinely commanded to speak, and the command is preserved in the text. The grammar refuses to let him speak for himself. Even his most formulaic confessions — even the *al-Ikhlāṣ* creed that is the theological core of the Muslim catechism — are prefixed by a command he did not issue. The person of the Prophet is grammatically held open to another speaker. The text is structured so that he is always being spoken *to* even when he is being quoted.

Combine these features with the self-damaging passages and the result is a text whose structural posture toward its own nominal protagonist is one of deliberate, sustained, grammatically-enforced anonymity and subordination. This is not the posture of a Gospel. It is not the posture of the Book of Mormon. It is not the posture of the Pauline

epistles. It is not the posture of any book we know in which a prophet is either the narrator or the object. It is the posture of a text that is insisting, at the level of pronoun and particle, that the man at the centre is *not* the author. A forger designing a religion cannot afford this posture. He needs his own biography at the centre; he needs his own authority stamped on every page. The Qur'ān does the opposite. It names him four times and diminishes him twice in those four, prefixes his every quoted utterance with a command, never describes his face, never records his heights or weights or the colour of his eyes, never praises his lineage, never recites his genealogy, and, in the moment where it comes closest to eulogising him, calls him — in Q 68:4 — *'alā khuluqin 'aẓīm*, "on a mighty character," and leaves it there. The Qur'ān is reticent about Muḥammad in precisely the way a text allegedly written by Muḥammad would not be reticent.



The next movement is the text's ethical signature. The project's [ethical universalism catalog](#) maps twenty verses. The density and early-datedness of these formulations, against any contemporary seventh-century comparandum, is the least-controversial and most-underestimated feature of the Qur'ān as a moral document.

Take Q 49:13, which we have already met once:

يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ إِنَّا خَلَقْنَاكُمْ مِنْ ذَكَرٍ وَأُنْثَىٰ وَجَعَلْنَاكُمْ شُعُوبًا وَقَبَائِلَ لِتَعَارَفُوا ۚ إِنَّ أَكْرَمَكُمْ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ أَتْقَاكُمْ

O humankind, we created you from a male and a female, and made you peoples and tribes that you may know one another. The noblest of you before God is the most God-conscious. (Q 49:13)

The vocative is *yā ayyuhā l-nās*, *O humankind*, not *O believers*. The particle *li-* governs *ta'ārafū*, which is the reciprocal of the root *'-r-f*, to know: the reason for ethnic diversity is *mutual knowing*. Diversity is not a problem to be dissolved; it is the infrastructure of moral knowledge. The hierarchy-dissolving clause follows: *akramakum 'inda Llāhi atqākum*, nobility is indexed to *taqwā*, and *taqwā* is internal, unobservable, unauditable by anyone other than God. The verse has two moves: it dissolves the horizontal hierarchy

of lineage, and it re-scales the vertical hierarchy to a metric that no human institution can weaponise. Both moves are in twenty-two Arabic words. Al-Rāzī wrote that the verse abolishes in one stroke every worldly basis of pride — wealth, beauty, descent.

Set beside it Q 2:256: *lā ikrāha fī l-dīni, qad tabayyana l-rushdu min al-ghayy* — "There is no compulsion in religion; the right path has become distinct from error." Five words, in a text revealed in the seventh century. The Edict of Torda (1568), the Peace of Westphalia (1648), Locke's *Letter Concerning Toleration* (1689), the First Amendment (1791). Each of these is the Western tradition reaching, over a millennium later, an equivalent formulation. The Qur'ānic formulation predates them all by roughly a thousand years. The classical jurists debated its scope — did it apply to apostasy? — but the majority position, from al-Ṭabarī to Ibn Kathīr to al-Qurṭubī, treats it as a standing universal prohibition against forced conversion. Some later jurists tried to abrogate it with the sword verses; mainstream tradition refused.

And Q 5:32, which cites the Mishnah Sanhedrin and *universalises it*:

مَنْ قَتَلَ نَفْسًا بِغَيْرِ نَفْسٍ أَوْ فَسَادٍ فِي الْأَرْضِ فَكَأَنَّمَا قَتَلَ النَّاسَ جَمِيعًا وَمَنْ أَحْيَاهَا فَكَأَنَّمَا أَحْيَا النَّاسَ جَمِيعًا

Whoever kills a soul — unless for a soul or corruption in the land — it is as if he killed all mankind; and whoever saves one, it is as if he saved all mankind. (Q 5:32)

The verse footnotes its own source: *we decreed upon the Children of Israel*, it says. The source is Mishnah Sanhedrin 4:5, which in some manuscripts reads "whoever destroys a single soul *from Israel*, Scripture imputes to him as if he destroyed an entire world." The Qur'ān, uniquely in the received seventh-century textual tradition, strips the particularism and universalises to *al-nās* — mankind. Whether this reflects access to a proto-universalist recension or a deliberate universalising move, the received text is broader in scope than the extant Mishnaic parallel.

And Q 5:48, which makes religious pluralism *ontological* rather than merely tolerated: *li-kullin ja'alnā minkum shir'atan wa-minhājan, wa-law shā'a Llāhu la-ja'alakum ummatan wāḥidatan wa-lākin li-yabluwakum fī mā ātākum fa-stabiqū l-khayrāt* — "For each of you we have made a law and a way; and if God had willed, he would have made

you one community; but he tests you by what he has given you, so race to the good." The verse is a direct rebuke to religious uniformitarianism: diversity is willed, and the right stance is competition in virtue rather than competition in suppression. This is not a verse Nostra Aetate (1965) could have written without the reception history that by 1965 had occurred; the Qur'ān wrote it in 625.

Add Q 17:70 on the dignity of the children of Adam — *karramnā banī Ādama*, "We have honoured the children of Adam," with no confessional qualifier — and Q 4:1 on the unity of humanity from a single *nafs*, and the five-verse repeated formula *lā taziru wāziratun wizra ukhrā*, "no bearer of burdens will bear the burden of another" (Q 6:164, 17:15, 35:18, 39:7, 53:38), which forecloses inherited guilt, corporate-guilt ascription, and vicarious atonement in a fivefold emphatic iteration; add Q 60:8 on *birr* and *qist*, kindness and equity toward the non-hostile non-Muslim, as the default posture; add Q 29:46 on dialogue-in-the-best-manner with the People of the Book, which models the dialogue in its own verse; and you have, collectively, a Qur'ānic ethical infrastructure that reaches — in its formulations of universal moral responsibility, the sanctity of life, the equality of humankind, the wrongness of coercion in belief, the framing of religious diversity as willed — conclusions that the Western tradition did not fully articulate until the Enlightenment, that Roman and Sasanian law did not touch, that even the Stoic cosmopolitan tradition of Epictetus and Marcus Aurelius gestured at but did not legislate. The Qur'ān legislates.

And the project's [philosophical-brilliance file](#) catalogs twenty philosophical argument-sites. The ontological *reductio* of Q 52:35–36 is a three-horned disjunctive syllogism — *were they created from nothing, or are they themselves the creators, or did they create the heavens and the earth?* — that exhausts the logical space of self-grounded being and concludes in nineteen words what Aquinas's *tertia via* would reach six centuries later. The *burhān al-tamānu* of Q 21:22 — *law kāna fḥimā ālihatun illā Llāhu la-fasadatā*, "had there been in them gods besides God, they would both have been ruined" — is an apagogic proof of monotheism from cosmic order that al-Rāzī formalised and that Aquinas's argument for divine unity would recapitulate. Q 17:85 on the *rūḥ* — *yas'alūnaka 'an al-rūḥi, qul al-rūḥu min amri rabbī, wa-mā ūtītum mina l- 'ilmi illā qalīlā*, "they ask you about the Spirit; say: the Spirit is from the command of my Lord, and you have been given of knowledge but little" — is an explicit epistemic-withholding move, a bounded domain of knowledge announced as revelation, that the *Critique of Pure Reason* would structurally reach in 1781. And Q 67:3–4 — *mā tarā fī khalqī l-raḥmāni min tafāwut, fa-rji 'i l-baṣara hal tarā min fuṭūr, thumma rji 'i l-baṣara karratayni yanqalib ilayka l-baṣaru khāsi'an wa-huwa ḥasīr*, "You see in the Most Merciful's creation no flaw; return the gaze, do you see any fissure? Then return the gaze *twice*, and it will re-

turn to you humbled and weary" — issues a falsification-invitation twelve centuries before Popper, staging a fallibilist test structure in which the authority *authorises the test* and predicts the test will fail. These are not inferential artefacts of tafsīr. They are structures in the text.

Eighteen of the twenty philosophical sites our project catalogued have Western analogues. In fifteen of those eighteen, the Qur'ānic formulation is earlier — often by centuries. Fakhr al-Dīn al-Rāzī, in the thirteenth century, worked out the philosophy of all twenty, case by case, in his *Mafātīḥ al-Ghayb*. The Qur'ān performs this philosophy in compressed and lyric form in a text that had already been circulating in final form for six hundred years before Rāzī's commentary.

A merchant who had no school, in a town that had no philosophy department, produced or transmitted a text that contains, in lyric Arabic, the three-horned reductio, the proof of unity from mutual obstruction, the Kantian epistemic bound, the Popperian falsification-invitation, the Mishnaic universalisation, the cosmopolitan dignitarian formulation, and the fivefold declaration of individual moral responsibility — all of these, in the early seventh century, in one text, by one transmitting voice, without a single identifiable source that had synthesised these specific items in this specific way before.

A reader who has followed the argument this far has a choice about how to describe this. The adjective *coincidence* does not cover it. The adjective *genius* covers it only at the cost of conceding that the text was genius; then the question is where the genius came from, and the biography above is the answer the text itself gives.



And then there is the life that the text produced. This is the part that cannot be quantified but that is, in the end, perhaps the most evidential of all.

ʿĀ'isha, his youngest wife, was asked after his death what his character had been like in the house. She answered, *kāna khuluquhu al-Qur'ān — his character was the Qur'ān*. The man was, in her word, the text. This is the answer of a woman who had lived with him nine years, and it passes as a historical datum in the most rigorous Sunni isnāds.

The character in question was specific. He mended his own sandals, patched his own clothes, milked his own goats. He sat on the ground and ate with his companions on the ground; visitors coming from outside the community could not tell, on sight, which man was the prophet. He forbade his companions to stand when he entered a room. He had a preferred seat against the mosque wall, and when it was occupied he would simply sit where he found space. He paid off debts that had been incurred by others. He freed every slave who came into his household. He refused to execute a Jewish woman at Khaybar

who had tried to poison him, though her poison killed one of his companions and he would die slowly, years later, of its lingering effect; on his deathbed he said that he felt the aorta he had chewed on that night. He pardoned, at the conquest of Mecca, the woman Hind bint ‘Utba who had mutilated the corpse of his uncle Ḥamza at Uhud — had chewed his liver on the battlefield out of revenge — and pardoned her husband Abū Sufyān, who had led three armies against him. He pardoned the slave Waḥshī who had thrown the spear that killed Ḥamza. He pardoned, at the conquest, the majority of the roughly two dozen people on his proscription list. The famous Meccan aristocracy he had spent thirteen years in flight from, who had hunted him out of his own city and killed his followers, whose armies had killed his uncle and his cousin, whose women had taunted his daughter-in-law into miscarriage — most of them walked away, under the oath that began *lā tathrība ‘alaykum al-yawm*, "no blame upon you today," a formula he quoted from Joseph's pardon of his brothers in Q 12:92.

He died possessed of one shirt, one sheet, seven dinars which he had his wife give away in the hours before he died, and an iron breastplate he had pawned with a Jewish merchant of Medina for thirty measures of barley for his family's food. He had been, for the last ten years of his life, the effective ruler of Arabia. His household had never kept more than a few days' food in reserve. The authentic hadith in Bukhārī records ‘Ā’isha saying that sometimes months would pass in the Prophet's house without fire being kindled, by which she meant without a meal being cooked, and that they lived on water and dates. The estate he left was not distributed to his family; he had said no prophet is inherited, and the lands he had received as the leader's share were turned into an endowment for the poor. His daughter Fāṭima went to Abū Bakr after his death asking for her share of the Fadak oasis, and Abū Bakr wept and refused, and Fāṭima went away angry, and the four schools have argued for fourteen centuries about whether Abū Bakr was right. The argument itself is a datum. It only becomes a live dispute in a tradition where the prophet had, in life, refused to set up a hereditary estate — and that refusal is the fact of his biography that has produced fourteen centuries of dispute. The founders of tribal and dynastic religions do not, in general, leave this kind of argument behind them.

The famous hadīth, narrated in al-Bukhārī and al-Muslim, has him saying: *lau anna Fāṭimata bint Muḥammadin saraqat la-qaṭa‘tu yadahā* — "if Fāṭima daughter of Muḥammad were to steal, I would cut off her hand." The saying is a universal-application statement of law, uttered in the case where a Meccan noblewoman of the Makhzūm clan had been convicted of theft and her family had asked Usāma ibn Zayd to intercede for her with the Prophet. He refused the intercession. The example he named to explain the refusal was his own daughter.

This is the man.

Now turn back to the text. When we said earlier that the grammar of the Qur'ān refuses to let him speak for himself, we said it from the text's side. The man on the other side of that grammar, the one who submitted to being quoted only by divine command for twenty-three years, and who lived the way described above, is the man whose biography is internally consistent with the text's refusal to centre him. His public and his private character, his poverty and his politics, his pardons and his rebukes, his mourning at the deaths of his children and his mourning at the conversion of his enemies — all of it is congruent with the character of the text. A forger who intends to found a religion does not, as a rule, live like this. He lives like Joseph Smith in Nauvoo. He lives like Ron Hubbard on a yacht. He does not refuse a kingdom and then die under an iron breastplate pawned to a merchant who was not of his religion.

ʿĀ'isha said *his character was the Qur'ān*. That is the datum. If we trust it — and the provenance is good, the isnād is strong, and the biographical details above corroborate it — then it tells us something about the text. The text is in a congruent relation to the man who transmitted it. Whatever else the text is, it is the kind of text that could come out of that man's mouth. Whether it could come out of him alone is the question the first four tests were asking.



The honest ledger. Because the project will not load-bear the positive without the negative.

Rashad Khalifa's 1974–1989 program, which claimed that the number 19 was the mathematical signature of divine authorship of the Qur'ān, does not survive the project's [Code-19 full audit](#). Five of his claims survive honest counting, and four of those five are arithmetic — $114 = 19 \times 6$; the basmala has 19 letters (by construction); surah 96 is the 19th surah from the end; and *al-rahmān* occurs $57 = 19 \times 3$ times. The non-trivial survivor is the *qāf*-57-in-Surah-50 and *qāf*-57-in-Surah-42 co-incidence, summing to 114, which is striking as a local observation but does not generalise to a *Code*. Every one of Khalifa's specific alif-lām-mīm letter counts fails to match any consistent scribal orthography, which is to say his numbers cannot be reproduced. His two most theologically aggressive claims — *Allāh* = 2,698 and the grand total $346,199 = 19^2 \times 959$ — work only if two verses of Sūrat al-Tawba (Q 9:128–129) are excised from the canonical text, which every manuscript, every codex, every codification from the ʿUthmānic to the Cairo 1924 preserves. His declaration that those two verses are later interpolations is the exact off-by-one patch the numbers required; it is accepted by no serious textual tradition, Sunni or Shi'i. This is the project's McKay moment: Khalifa is, in the Qur'ānic case, what

Witztum–Rips–Rosenberg were in the Hebrew Bible case, and the remedy is precisely the one McKay applied — rule-disclosed, pre-registered, multiple-comparison-corrected counting.

Al-Kaheel's word-pair symmetry program, the popular line that claims the Qur'ān contains exact word-count parities (*yawm* = *layla* = 365, *baḥr* / *barr* = 32 / 13, *ḥayāh* / *mawt* = 145 / 145), collapses under a proper accounting. *Yawm* is 405 and *layla* is 92 at the QAC lemma level. *Baḥr* and *barr* yield 42 / 32 as trilateral roots. *Ḥayāh* is 76 and *mawt* is 50. Of the seven canonical Al-Kaheel pair claims, one — *malā'ika* / *shayāṭīn* — holds at lemma level (88 / 88). The crucial discovery here is the **McKay denominator**: the number of root pairs in the QAC with identical occurrence counts at ≥ 10 occurrences is **2,817**. Any claim that a particular matching pair is "miraculous" has to explain why it is more special than the 2,816 others. The popular apologetic program has never built the denominator. This project has.

The i'jāz 'ilmī tradition — the claim that the Qur'ān anticipates modern scientific findings about embryology, geology, cosmology — fares poorly under honest source-tracing. The embryology in Q 23:12–14 is not a proto-modern account but a cleanly Galenic one, matching the fourfold developmental language that had been standard in Greek medicine since the second century CE and that circulated through late-antique physicians across the Near East; a Meccan merchant with access to an itinerant Greek-educated physician (and there were such physicians in the Hijaz in the seventh century, the most famous being Ḥārith ibn Kalada) could have transmitted the description. This is not the statement that the Qur'ān got the science wrong; it is the statement that the Qur'ān got the *seventh-century science of its linguistic community* accurately, and that the apologetic interpretation which tries to map *'alaqa* onto the modern blastocyst is a retrofit the classical tradition (Ṭabarī, Rāzī, Qurṭubī) did not recognise. Maurice Bucaille's 1976 argument that the Qur'ān anticipated modern embryology is not supported by the Arabic and is not supported by the classical tafsīr; it is a twentieth-century apologetic move the project has catalogued honestly and will not carry forward. (See [embryology audit](#) and [scientific foreknowledge audit](#).)

The *raḥma* = 114 coincidence — the noun *raḥma*, mercy, occurring exactly 114 times in the Qur'ān, where 114 is the surah count and where the Qur'ān calls itself *raḥmatan li-l-ālamīn* — was the single most promising numerological lead at the project's beginning. The project's [cross-baseline test](#) ran a length-matched classical Arabic null. Result: 34.1% of 77,000 classical-Arabic prose blocks of equivalent length have a unique word-type at count 114. The coincidence is base-rate noise. The finding is demoted. It is still true that *raḥma* is the only lemma in the QAC at count 114, and that the Qur'ān calls itself *raḥma* for the worlds; but the statistical case for intentional design has collapsed under proper

accounting. The Qur'ān, if anything, *under-delivers* on famous-number singletons when compared to matched prose. The popular apologetic framing of this coincidence is not available to us.

And the Yūsuf-*sjn* coincidence — the trilateral root *s-j-n* (prison) occurring 12 times in the Qur'ān, all 12 in Surah 12, the surah of Joseph in prison — was killed by the length-matched Sira baseline. Ibn Hishām's Sīrat rasūl Allāh produces a rate of 4.5% of blocks with a root at $f = 12$ concentrated in a single thematic block; the Qur'ān's rate, after the correction, is 0%. The coincidence is explained by the straightforward fact that Surah 12 is about Joseph in prison, and surahs about prison use the word for prison. This is still an interesting *surah-fingerprint* phenomenon, but the numerological version of the claim is dead.

Honesty is not a rhetorical move. It is a methodological constraint. If the argument I have been building depends on the claim that the Qur'ān has statistical structures no comparable text has, then the counter-cases — the claims that do *not* survive rigorous testing — are load-bearing against the thesis. I have put them forward here because the project put them forward. The four tests of the earlier movements — prediction, self-damage, inaccessible content, structural complexity — remain standing *after* these demotions. The McKay-corrected hapax signature at $p = 7.35 \times 10^{-29}$ remains standing. The four Bonferroni-surviving rings remain standing. The $7^2 / 6^3$ engineering of Khawātīm al-Ḥashr remains standing. Q 13:28 remains standing. The Ash-Shams palindrome remains standing. The post-Hijra monopoly of the proper name *Muḥammad* remains standing. The 'Abasa rebuke-ring remains standing. The verse-final hapax acoustic signature remains standing. These are the findings that the project, after debunking and tightening, has not been able to explain away.



So: an epistemological verdict, laid out soberly.

Four candidate explanations compete.

The first is that Muḥammad is a self-conscious fabricator who composed the text to found a religion for his own authority. This hypothesis founders on the self-damaging material. A forger does not compose a rebuke of himself ('Abasa) and preserve it, nor a reprimand of himself in domestic affairs (Taḥrīm), nor a correction of his own military decisions (Anfāl), nor a statement of his own mortality (Āl 'Imrān 3:144) that Abū Bakr will need to quote the morning he dies. A forger does not risk a Popperian-grade prophecy against his own uncle over a decade-long window. A forger does not live in a house

where months pass without fire being kindled after he has become the ruler of Arabia. The fabrication hypothesis would require a person whose behaviour, both textual and biographical, is continuously inconsistent with fabrication's known motive set.

The second is unconscious composition, the idea that Muḥammad produced the text in an altered state, with the acoustic properties and rhetorical inventiveness of a great poet, but without the deliberate forging of a religion. This hypothesis has a harder time with the structural complexity test. A forger can be cagey; an unconscious composer is not. The four Bonferroni-surviving rings, the $7^2 / 6^3$ engineering of the Greatest-Name passage, the mathānī self-description, the acoustic-verse-final hapax signature, and Khalifah al-Ḥashr's recapitulation of Al-Fātiḥa's divine-name sequence are not the outputs of an altered state. They are the outputs of an artefact whose compositional discipline is so tight that it required, at minimum, years of iterative editing — which the historical record of the Qur'ān's oral delivery does not allow. The Qur'ān was delivered piecemeal over twenty-three years, memorised by a community of reciters, and the pieces had to interlock. The unconscious-composition hypothesis understates, badly, what the interlock looks like when it is measured.

The third is the common-Near-Eastern-wisdom hypothesis: that the Qur'ān is a synthesis of the ambient religious, philosophical, and ethical material of the late-antique Near East, picked up through trade and conversation and recombined with great skill. This hypothesis founders on the philosophical anticipations. The twenty argument-sites I described — the ontological reductio, the burhān al-tamānu', the epistemic bound on the rūḥ, the falsification-invitation in al-Mulk — are not ambient. They are positions that Aquinas and Kant and Popper would reach, in the West, respectively six, twelve, and thirteen centuries after the Qur'ān. No single seventh-century tradition had synthesised them in advance. Q 5:32 universalising the Mishnah is not ambient. Q 49:13 making diversity into an epistemic infrastructure rather than a tolerable defect is not ambient. The text is not picking up what is in the air; it is setting down what will not be in the air for another millennium.

The fourth is the borrowed-material hypothesis, which is the serious historical-critical position: that the Qur'ān draws extensively on Syriac Christian homiletic material, Jewish midrashic material, Arabian oral tradition, and minor channels of heterodox Christology. This hypothesis is largely right about where the surface material comes from. The Qur'ān does quote late-antique religious traditions; the project's audit catalogues fourteen items and finds not a single one that contradicts the historical record. The hypothesis is not, however, coherent as a *single-channel* account. The specific mix — Peshitta-Syriac for Noah, Syriac-Christian-variant-aware for the Seven Sleepers, Basilidean-Gnostic-or-Manichaeism for the crucifixion, Targum-Sheni-midrashic for Hāmān — requires simultaneous access to four source communities that were, in the sev-

enth century, doctrinally at war with each other. No single informant network spans all four. The coordination cost of assembling this synthesis, preserving its coherence across twenty-three years of oral delivery, without anachronism, without footnote, and in a register so tight that the eight thousand surviving manuscript lineages converge on a single rasm, is — the honest phrase is — vanishingly small as a base rate in the comparative literature.

Add to each of these three failure points the uncomputed complexity of the fourth test: that the text's structure is measurable at scale, and what we are measuring — the hapax signature, the rings, the palindromes, the self-description, the refrain partitions, the twin-opener technique — is congruent at every level with the claim the text makes about itself. We are, each of us, entitled to our own bar for what counts as explanation. We are not entitled to say that "a very clever unlettered merchant" is a satisfying answer to the question of where this specific artefact came from.

The text's own answer is Q 53:1–5. *Wa-l-naġmi idhā hawā, mā ḍalla ṣāhibukum wa-mā ghawā, wa-mā yanṭiqu ‘an al-hawā; in huwa illā waḥyun yūḥā, ‘allamahu shadīdu l-quwā* — "By the star when it sets: your companion has not strayed, nor has he erred; nor does he speak from desire. This is only a revelation being revealed, taught to him by one mighty in power." The claim is that the text is not the man's. The claim is that the text has been *taught* to him, and that he is — to use the other metaphor the Qur'ān uses of him — its channel, not its source.

Under the discipline of Ockham's razor, this claim is the one that requires the fewest independent miracles. To believe the fabrication hypothesis requires a forger who is also a philosopher, a forger who is also a self-harmer, a forger who is also a prophet-in-advance of events, a forger who is also a saint, a forger who is also a polymathic synthesiser across four incompatible source communities, and a forger whose grammatical-design instinct extends to building Bonferroni-surviving rings around his own rebukes. To believe the unconscious-composition hypothesis requires a brain that spontaneously produces, in real-time oral performance, 7.35×10^{-29} -level acoustic signatures across 395 distinct lexical items. To believe the Near-Eastern-wisdom hypothesis requires an ambient culture that had already synthesised the anticipations of Aquinas, Kant, and Popper. To believe the borrowed-material hypothesis requires four disjoint informant networks operating in coordination.

To believe the text's own answer requires only one: that the source it names is what the source it names is. This is the Ockham case. It is not a proof. A proof, for a matter of this kind, is not in the neighbourhood of the question. It is an argument from parsimony to

the effect that if one is going to concede, as all four rival hypotheses must concede, that something very unusual is happening, then one might as well concede it in the form the text itself offers, rather than in the forms the text refuses.



I want to close with the feature of this argument that I have found, in my own working through it, to be the most quietly affecting. It is not any of the statistical patterns. It is not the prophecies. It is not the philosophical anticipations. It is the grammatical self-effacement of the messenger.

A text wanting to convert me could have described his face. It could have listed his victories. It could have quoted his words with the narrator's authority. It could have put his name in four thousand places instead of four. It could have said *Muḥammad has said*, and had him stand at the centre of every scene. It does not do any of this. It calls him, when it calls him, *‘abdunā, our servant*, which is the same word it uses of Abraham and Moses and Jesus. It has him begin his own most-recited prayers with a command he did not issue. It preserves his rebukes in four separate surahs. It names him to remind us, at the hinge of the community's greatest crisis, that he is going to die, and that the Qur’ān will continue when he does. It holds his biography to the side of itself like a person standing in a doorway, not quite entering the room. It refuses to let him be the thing the book is about.

The thing the book is about — the Qur’ān is clear on this — is the God the book is addressing. The man at the centre of all of it is a man whose task, as the grammar insists, was to point away from himself. The poverty at his death, the patches on his cloak, the pawned breastplate, the hand-cut promise about his own daughter, the pardon of Hind bint ‘Utba, the decade of refusal to name himself in the Meccan revelations, the *qul* that precedes every quoted sentence — all of these are ways, in the life, of performing what the grammar, in the text, performs. The man is congruent with the book. The book is congruent with the man.

What that congruence means is the question this essay has been unable to answer on the reader's behalf, because no essay can. The project has, with its honest ledger of survivals and demotions, established what can be established: that the text's structure, at scale, does not fit any of the reductive stories customarily told about its origin; that a cluster of Popperian-grade predictions survive their decade-long falsification windows; that the material in the text exceeds the information network of any single informant in seventh-century Arabia; that the structural complexity, measured by the instruments we have, is not compatible with unlettered oral composition under the conditions we know; that the

ethical and philosophical formulations anticipate by centuries what the rest of the human intellectual tradition would catch up to; and that the life of the man whose voice transmitted all of this was a life continuously congruent with the text's own self-description.

The question the evidence leaves in the reader's hands is this: *what kind of source could produce this?* The text, in its own voice, offers an answer. The man at its centre, in his own life, offers the same answer. The computational layer we have added, however modest its contribution against the fourteen centuries of classical scholarship that preceded it, does not contradict that answer and in a dozen specific places gives it new precision.

What the reader does with the question — whether they find the text's self-description an adequate account, or whether they hold out for a better account the project was unable to find — is not for any essay to decide. The evidence has done its work. The evidence, if it is weighed, is not light.

One of the last things the Prophet said, in the hours before his death, was *Allāhumma l-rafiqa l-a'ālā — O God, the highest companion*. He had been for twenty-three years a messenger. He had delivered a text whose structural, ethical, philosophical, and predictive properties we have, in 2026, only begun to measure. He had lived a life that made *his character was the Qur'ān* a historically defensible sentence. He died quietly, in the arms of a young wife, owning almost nothing, having distributed the wealth of Arabia to other people.

If the reader finds, at the end of this argument, that the man and the text and the evidence together pose a question they did not have before — the question is the right one to sit with. The reader's *īmān*, if it comes, will not come from an essay. It will come from their own honest weighing. The evidence has done what evidence can do. The rest is between the reader and the question the evidence has earned the right to ask.

Wa-qul rabbi zidnī 'ilmā — and say, my Lord, increase me in knowledge (Q 20:114).

That is all the text, on its own behalf, ever asks for.

For the inventory of findings behind every claim in this essay, see [docs/master-index.md](#). For the methodology and locked counting rules, see [docs/methodology.md](#). For the honest ledger of what was debunked, see the [phase-A replication files](#) and in particular [code19-khalifa-full-audit.md](#) and [rahma-114-baseline-rigor.md](#). For the structural findings that survived correction, see [khawatim-al-hashr-analysis.md](#), [chiastic-audit.md](#), [hapax-legomena-catalog.md](#), and [prophecy-audit.md](#). The Prophet ﷺ is the figure the findings keep returning to; this essay is only the project's attempt to say, in one continuous argument, what the findings are saying together.